



tion of political families that are increasingly tightening their hold on the system. Nehru's democratic credentials were somewhat blemished when he made his daughter the president of the Indian National Congress. Two decades later, Indira faced charges of trying to foster dynastic rule when she brought in, first Sanjay and following his death, Rajiv Gandhi into politics. But the shrieks against dynastic succession soon began to fade as more and more leaders drafted their sons and daughters and near relatives into politics at the expense of others who had served their organisations far longer.

From north to south, east to west, political outfits are increasingly becoming family-owned private enterprises. Farooq Abdullah is succeeded by Omar; in Haryana, young Deepender will one day take over from Bhupinder Singh Hooda just as Om Prakash Chautala did from Tau Devi Lal; in Uttar Pradesh, Mulayam Singh will sooner or later pass on the baton to Akhilesh as will Sharad Pawar in Maharashtra whose only daughter Supriya Sule is already earning her spurs in the Lok Sabha; the most powerful Congress MP from Andhra Pradesh is not a veteran front bencher but the debutante Jagan Mohan Reddy, son of Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy, and DMK patriarch M. Karunanidhi has ensured something for everyone in his extended family, making his elder son and a grandnephew Union ministers, his younger son Tamil Nadu's deputy chief minister and his daughter an MP. At the rate political dynasties are proliferating, the day is not far off when it will be hard to find an MP, minister or chief minister whose father or uncle hasn't been there before.

It is nobody's contention that democracy and dynasty are non-compatible. But what is frightening are the attempts to return to the old style oligarchy where a few dominant families wield all the power, where democracies' beneficiaries are these very families and all its spinoffs are reserved exclusively for their constituencies. Nehru set up giant Public Sector Units (PSU)—the commanding heights of the Indian economy, as he liked them to be known—in far flung and remote corners of the country so their benefits are spread evenly. Today, there are not too many PSUs setting up new shop, but the private sector is being wooed by the new urban, foreign-educated elitist leaders to build factories and plants in the already crowded urban

jungles. And only the foolhardy or the extraordinarily brave—a rarity amongst the business class—will turn his back on this breed of well-heeled, well-connected politicians.

Political dynasties have many distinct advantages that conventional politicians don't have. Money is never in short supply, the machinery is always at their command and followers easily drummed up, all reasons why politics, as it is practiced now, bears little resemblance to the way it used to be. Earlier, leaders jumped in to join the crowds because there was hardly a rope to keep the two apart; now AK-47 wielding security guards make sure that the people are kept as far as possible. Consequently, leaders are no more able to feel the pulse of the people and therefore unable to ideate enough. Ironically, it is Rahul Gandhi, among the most protected persons in the country, who frequently sheds his ubiquitous security and genuinely seeks to reach out to the people. The tragedy is there are too few like him.

Since 1980, this magazine has periodically conducted opinion polls to gauge the mood of the people on a wide range of issues. In one such poll conducted more than two decades after her assassination, an overwhelming majority of Indians voted Indira Gandhi as the best

75%

of the country's population is aged under 35, yet 84-year-old Atal Bihari Vajpayee who demitted office five years ago continues to be one of the most popular politicians. This is proof enough that India judges its leaders by the breadth of their ideas and the audacity of their actions.

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prime minister India ever had, surpassing even her illustrious father. In successive polls from the late 1990s onwards, Atal Bihari Vajpayee has towered over all others in terms of ratings and continued to occupy the No.1 spot long after he demitted office in 2004. If these polls carry a message, it is that India judges its leaders by the breadth of their ideas and the audacity of their actions. We live in the age of hollow men and holograms.

We are a young country, 75 per cent of whose population is aged under 35. We have many young and bright leaders but they are not action heroes of change. They have neither a mission nor a message that can transform the nation. Ultimately, leadership boils down to ideas and translating them into action and not the office you occupy through an accident of history or manipulative politics. These can keep you in office but will not get you a place in the hearts and minds of Indians. ■